Energy during the super debate, sent a letter to J. Edgar Hoover saying, in part: “The purpose of this letter is to state my own exhaustively considered opinion, based upon years of study of the available classified evidence, that more probably than not J. Robert Oppenheimer is an agent of the Soviet Union.” Oppenheimer’s security clearance was canceled, and in April and May of 1954, simultaneous with the first American tests of deliverable hydrogen bombs, the Atomic Energy Commission conducted hearings to determine whether or not Oppenheimer was really a security risk.

Box 6.2

Why Did Soviet Physicists Build the Bomb for Stalin?

Why did Zel’dovich, Sakharov, and other great Soviet physicists work so hard to build atomic bombs and hydrogen bombs for Joseph Stalin? Stalin was responsible for the deaths of millions of Soviet citizens: 6 million or 7 million peasants and kulaks in forced collectivization in the early 1930s, 2.5 million from the top strata of the military, government, and society in the Great Terror of 1937–39, 10 million from all strata of society in the prisons and labor camps of the 1930s through 1950s. How could any physicist, in good conscience, put the *ultimate* weapon into the hands of such an *evil* man?

Those who ask such questions forget or don’t know the conditions—physical and psychological—that pervaded the Soviet Union in the late 1940s and early 1950s:

1. The Soviet Union had just barely emerged from the bloodiest, most devastating war in its history—a war in which Germany, the aggressor, had killed 27 million Soviet people and had laid waste to their homeland—when Winston Churchill fired an early salvo of the cold war: In a 5 March 1946 speech in Fulton, Missouri, Churchill warned the West about a Soviet threat and coined the phrase “iron curtain” to describe the boundaries that Stalin had established around his empire. Stalin’s propaganda machinery milked Churchill’s speech for all it could, creating a deep fear among Soviet citizens that the British and Americans might attack. The